mispricing," says Nandwani. It's no surprise then that the stock is currently trading at one-fifth of its listed price, he adds. That's when Sharma started faltering. Ironically, it was the time that BYJU'S Raveendran began to peak.

THE ASCENT OF BYJU'S

Byju Raveendran's story is no less fascinating than Sharma's. Until he was 20, Raveendran lived in Azhikode, a suburb of the coastal city of Kannur in Kerala, where his parents were teachers in the government high school. A sports fanatic who played cricket, football and table tennis at the university level, he learned English listening to cricket commentary on the radio and earned a mechanical engineering degree from the Government Engineering College in Kannur. After his graduation, Raveendran joined a ship management firm, which allowed him to travel the world for the next three years handling vessel repair and breakdown. On his annual vacations back home, Raveendran would connect with friends in Bengaluru, some of whom were working in IT firms and preparing for the Common Admission Test (CAT), a competitive exam to get into MBA programmes. Raveendran, who loves mathematics, found that he had a natural aptitude to teach. In 2006, he held his first Sunday morning session for a batch of 35—all friends and their acquaintances—in Bengaluru's Koramangala neighbourhood. By the sixth session, what started off as a vacation pastime drew as many as 1,200 students, word having spread among serious aspirants in tech circles, mostly via social messaging service Orkut. The sessions then moved into bigger auditoriums and Raveendran was soon travelling to Chennai, Pune and Mumbai, where his classes were in great demand. It was the end of his shipping career.

In 2011, Raveendran incorporated Think & Learn (T&L) Private Limited, the company that owns the BYJU'S brand and, a year later, began raising seed funding to take his popular classes into a hybrid online video format. Raveendran and family own 26.3 per cent in BYJU'S. By 2015, BYJU'S was phasing out its physical classes to become a tech-enabled firm via its own learning app, which students from kindergarten to class 12 could access through a tablet. BYJU'S was already a unicorn with a valuation of over $1 billion by 2018. And when the Covid pandemic struck, BYJU'S hit pay dirt, as parents scrambled to enrol their children for online classes as schools remained closed for longer periods. Revenue for the firm flowed from subscriptions for its online learning app, which dispensed, among other things, early learning material for Lower Kindergarten to Class 3, self-study packs, live classes and video lessons for Classes 4 upwards, and online live classes and

BYJU'S

CRASH COURSE

BYJU'S descent has been as swift as its rise to the top of the edtech universe, where it was an undisputed leader

THE BYJU'S EMPIRE

OFFLINE

- **AAKASH**
  300 centres plus hybrid model for test preparation for entrance exams such as JEE/ NEET
- **BYJU'S TUITION CENTRES**
  300 centres plus hybrid classes

ONLINE

- **BYJU'S EARLY LEARN**
  for K-3 segment
- **BYJU'S THE LEARNING APP**
  for Classes 4-10
- **BYJU'S CLASSES**
  after-school learning solution
- **BYJU'S EXAM PREP**
  for entrance tests from CAT to UPSC exams

A SPATE OF ACQUISITIONS

The companies BYJU'S has acquired in the past few years, and the amounts it paid for them

(Purchase price in $ million)

Aakash	950
Great Learning	600
Epic	500
WhiteHat Jr*	300
Tynker	200
Scholr	180
Toppr	150
Gradeup	50
GeoGebra	24

**Acquired in 2020; rest of the deals were made in 2021*
Source: Company announcements

Raveendran was always accused of being coy with sharing the company's financials with investors, but as long as its valuation was high, the investors played along